



ALLIANCE PROTOCOLS

The Architecture of Staying

WHY DELIBERATE DESIGN HELPS RELATIONSHIPS
THAT LOVE ALONE CAN'T HOLD

We are an alliance.
Built for precision. Designed for connection.

by David and Dami · Volume A · Version 1.2

A NOTE BEFORE YOU START

Every couple in this book is a composite, with names and details changed, stitched together from patterns common enough that you'll recognise pieces of your own week in them. None of them is anyone's real marriage. The patterns are the point, not the people. Two things are ours: 'The Third Voice' is our own story, told by David with a few details changed, and the Prologue couple, Mara and Theo, are invented but their fight is based on an argument of ours (the Third Voice says how).

This book sits beside the Alliance Protocols Operating Manual. It tells the stories behind the tools; it doesn't replace them. Where this book names a pattern, the Manual gives you the tool. Think of it this way: this book is the why, the Manual is the reference, the Field Kit is a folder of cards with its map on the fridge, and the free Field App is for when it's actually happening.

This book is for couples who are safe with each other. If you are afraid of your partner, or of anyone in your home, it is not for this: please get outside help first.

ⓧ IF YOU'RE NOT SAFE — HELP LINES

This book is about couples who are frustrated, drifting, or stuck — not about anyone who is afraid. If you're afraid of your partner, being threatened, or not free to say no, stop here: these tools are not for this. Get outside help.

Immediate danger: your local emergency number (999 UK/SG police · 995 SG ambulance · 911 US · 000 AU · 112 EU). Singapore, if you can't speak: SMS 70999 (police).

Domestic abuse: US National Domestic Violence Hotline 1-800-799-7233 (text START to 88788) · UK National Domestic Abuse Helpline (Refuge) 0808 2000 247 · Australia 1800RESPECT 1800 737 732 · Singapore National Anti-Violence & Sexual Harassment Helpline 1800 777 0000 · EU 116 016

Sexual violence, including from a partner: US RAINN 800-656-4673 (text HOPE to 64673) · UK Rape Crisis England & Wales 0808 500 2222 · Australia 1800RESPECT (1800 737 732) · Singapore AWARE Sexual Assault Care Centre 6779 0282 (weekdays 10am to 6pm)

Feeling at the end of your rope: Samaritans (UK) 116 123 · 988 (US, call or text) · Lifeline (AU) 13 11 14 · SOS (SG) 1767

Full Help Lines: the last page of the Field Kit and the Manual's front matter, with lines for LGBTQ+ people, for a child at risk, for men experiencing abuse and for worry about your own behaviour; also allianceprotocols.com/help. Numbers checked October 2026.

If someone checks your phone or books, keep this somewhere private.

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PROLOGUE

The Kitchen at 9.40pm

The kitchen could be anyone's.

Mara is standing at the sink with her hands in water that's gone cold, and she can't remember what she's supposed to be doing with them.

Behind her, Theo is still talking. Not loudly. That's almost the worst part — if he were shouting, she'd know where she stood. Instead his voice has that flat, reasonable register he gets when he thinks he's being patient, which somehow lands harder than shouting ever did.

"I'm not saying it's a big deal," he says. "I'm saying you said you'd call the plumber, and it's been eleven days."

It isn't about the plumber. They both know it isn't about the plumber. But neither of them can find the actual thing underneath it, so they keep circling the plumber like it's the only solid ground in the room.

Forty minutes ago they were fine. They'd eaten dinner, split a bottle of wine, laughed about something Theo's manager said in a meeting, and Theo had already posted the card for her sister's birthday. Then Theo mentioned the sink drain, Mara said something clipped about being tired of being the one who remembers things, and now — this. A kitchen. Cold water. A conversation neither of them chose to have, going somewhere neither of them wants it to go, as if it had decided on its own.

"You always do this," Theo says.

"Do what?" Her own voice has gone flat and reasonable too. She can hear it.

"Turn it into me being the bad guy for asking a normal question."

"I'm not turning it into anything. I'm just *tired*, Theo."

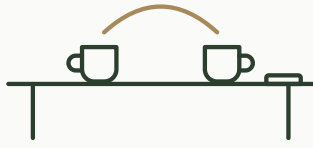
And there it is — the word that ends the conversation without ending the fight. Mara goes quiet. Theo takes the quiet as confirmation he was right to feel unheard, and pushes once more, gently, which is the wrong kind of gentle right

now. Mara says she needs a minute. Theo says fine, in the tone that means it isn't. She goes to the bedroom. He stays in the kitchen, staring at a drain that, to be fair, really has been slow for eleven days.

Neither of them is a bad partner. Neither of them did anything a stranger reading a transcript would call cruel. And yet here they are, on a Tuesday night, two rooms and a long way apart, over a plumber neither of them has called.

You could call this a communication problem, in the vague, poster-in-a-therapist's-waiting-room sense of that phrase. They already communicate, technically: words came out of both their mouths, in the correct order, forming complete sentences. What neither of them had was a map for what was happening between them, and so both of them improvised, and the improvisation made it worse.

This book is about what a map would have shown them.



A NOTE FROM US

The Third Voice

Nobody plans the fight about the algorithm. That's the whole problem.

David and Dami — and, in some ways, the dogs

Told by David. (Dami is Zhongming; it's what everyone calls him.)

It started with a text — a logistics question, nothing loaded in it, that I read three times and decided was an accusation. Dami was asleep. The old dog, ten years old and rescued from a shelter, was asleep too, in the specific full-body way of a dog who has correctly assessed that nothing currently requires him. The puppy, ten months old and newly arrived, was not asleep — the puppy is never asleep at the hours that matter — and was doing laps of the living room for reasons that remain entirely her own. So I did what any reasonable person does at eleven at night: I opened a chatbot. It gave me three bullet points, a suggested reply, and a reassurance that my feelings were valid. It did not ask why I was telling a machine instead of walking down the hall. That was the first time.

By the fifth time it was a habit — not for the big stuff, but the hundred small frictions a week that don't warrant a real Pause + Return (the pause tool you'll meet in Chapter II) but leave residue if handled badly. Here's one evening, lightly changed, told without names. One partner's old friends slide into Mandarin the moment he sits down with them: twenty years of habit, not exclusion. The other partner goes to the bot afterwards instead of to him — *am I overreacting?* — and gets back a beautifully drafted case for how a good partner would notice, when what was needed was to say it out loud. Asked directly, the first partner had a less dramatic version: he hadn't noticed, and once told, he fixes it without being asked twice. The fix takes four seconds. Building the case takes forty-five minutes.

A 2026 study in *Science* by Myra Cheng and colleagues found that chatbots side with whoever is typing, affirming them about 50% more than people do, and that one flattering conversation left people less willing to repair the conflict. They rated the flattering bot higher for it, and trusted it more. Ours wasn't a shared chatbot. It was a private advisor, loyal to one of us, turning the other person into a puzzle instead of a partner.

Madeleine Clare Elish has a phrase for what happens when an automated system fails and the nearest human absorbs the blame: a “moral crumple zone”. We borrow it loosely, and the application to couples is our analogy, not hers. A private advisor never takes the hit; the person across the table does.

The fight that broke it open was a real one, about something small and domestic — call it the dishwasher. Dami said something sharp. I answered with a well-built sentence that acknowledged his feeling and requested a specific behavioural change. “Who are you talking to?” Dami said. “That sentence. That wasn’t you. That was your bot.” He was right. That night he told me, “I don’t want to be in a relationship with your chatbot. I want to be in a relationship with you.”

A fair question, since the Manual is full of suggested sentences: isn’t a script just a bot on paper? We don’t think so. The scripts are training wheels. Use your own words as soon as you can. A script you’ve chosen, understood and mean is a way of finding your own words; a sentence a bot wrote for you, about a partner it has never met, is a way of skipping them. What mattered all along was who was saying it.

The Alliance started as a rule made up on the spot: no bots for a month. It was harder than expected — real fights, messy ones, two nights of going to bed angry. But without the filter, we started hearing each other again — the unpolished versions, the ones who sometimes needed a full minute of silence before they could say what was wrong. The  System Overlay, said by the two people in it in their own words, came out of week two, when I noticed I’d lost tolerance for that messy, wordless part of a hard conversation. The bot had been sparing me exactly the work I needed to do myself. That rule became our working agreement, and the rest of the tools came over the years after.

We still use AI — for drafting difficult emails, rehearsing hard conversations with a boss — but never as a participant in the conversation that matters. One study (Yuan et al., 2026) found something we learned the hard way: the support can be real, but over time companion use coincided with more signs of distress. Another (Fang et al., 2025) linked heavier daily use with more loneliness and dependence. Both are associations, not proven causes. A relationship that never asks anything of you isn’t a relationship. It’s a mirror.

One more thing about the Prologue you have just read. The plumber and the eleven days are invented, but the shape of Mara and Theo’s fight is borrowed from ours: a small domestic thing standing in for something neither of us could name; one of us saying something sharp; the other answering in that flat, reasonable register that lands harder than shouting, which in our kitchen was the voice of a sentence a bot had helped build. It was one real fight, and that month it had plenty of smaller relatives. We tell this story knowing it doesn’t make us look wise. It makes us look like two people who nearly let a tool do the work only they could do — while, for the record, a ten-year-old rescue and a ten-month-old puppy kept doing their jobs the entire time without any outside

assistance. The decision that keeps the algorithm from taking over is the same one, made over and over, on ordinary evenings: turn towards the person in the room instead of the voice in the phone. Everything else is scaffolding.

GO DEEPER Manual Ch 2 (The Short Version) · Kit card: System Overlay

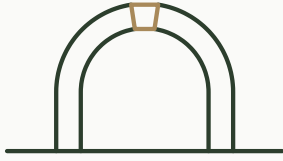
SOURCES FOR THIS CHAPTER

Cheng, M. et al. “Sycophantic AI decreases prosocial intentions and promotes dependence.” *Science* 391(6792) (2026); preprint arXiv:2510.01395 (2025). Across 11 models, AI affirmed users’ actions about 50% more than humans did; three experiments, N = 2,405.

Elish, M. C. “Moral Crumple Zones: Cautionary Tales in Human-Robot Interaction.” *Engaging Science, Technology, and Society* 5 (2019): 40–60. Elish coined “moral crumple zone” for what happens when an automated system fails and the nearest human absorbs the blame. We borrow it loosely: when a private advisor’s framing goes wrong between two partners, the tool never takes the hit; the person across the table does. The application to couples is the authors’ analogy, not Elish’s.

Yuan, Y., Zhang, J., Aledavood, T., Zhang, R. & Saha, K. “Mental Health Impacts of AI Companions: Triangulating Social Media Quasi-Experiments, User Perspectives, and Relational Theory.” *Proceedings of the 2026 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems* (CHI 2026); preprint arXiv:2509.22505 (2025). Aalto University-led; Reddit data from Replika users a year before and after first use, plus interviews. Reports an association between companion use and signs of distress, not a cause.

Fang, C. M. et al. “How AI and Human Behaviors Shape Psychosocial Effects of Chatbot Use: A Longitudinal Randomized Controlled Study.” Preprint arXiv:2503.17473 (2025). MIT Media Lab and OpenAI; four-week randomised controlled study, n = 981; heavier daily use was associated with more loneliness and emotional dependence (an association, not proof of cause).



CHAPTER I

The Myth of “If We Just Love Each Other Enough”

Love is the reason, not the method.

Here is a sentence that sounds wise and is almost completely useless:
relationships take work.

Everyone says it. Nobody explains what the work actually is. It’s the relationship equivalent of being told to “eat healthier”: true, unobjectionable, and no help at all at eight in the evening when you’re standing in front of an open fridge with no plan.

Most people go into a serious relationship with exactly one theory: if the love is real enough, the rest will sort itself out. Good intentions, deep feeling, the right person. Surely that covers it. And for a while, it does. Early on, novelty does a huge amount of the work for you. You’re curious about each other by default. You *want* to ask how the day went. Small generosity costs nothing because the whole thing still feels a little bit like a gift you can’t quite believe you got.

Then time passes, and novelty stops doing the work.

Nothing has gone wrong; that’s what novelty does. Novelty is a startup grant, not a salary, and every long relationship eventually has to work out what to live on once the grant is spent. The couples who don’t figure this out don’t usually fall apart in one dramatic rupture. They drift. Drift sounds passive, like something that happens *to* a relationship. It isn’t. It’s a thousand small, forgivable non-decisions. Skip one real conversation because you’re tired. Let one small hurt go unnamed because raising it feels disproportionate. Answer “how are you” with “fine” because the honest answer would take longer than either of you has right now. None of these is a betrayal. Added up over a few years of ordinary weeks, they’re how two people who genuinely love each other end up feeling like colleagues who share a mortgage.

Mara and Theo didn’t stop loving each other somewhere between the wine and the sink. What happened is smaller and stranger than that, and it’s worth slowing down for. A low-stakes comment about *the plumber* hit an assumption

neither of them had looked at: *I'm the one who remembers things, always, and it's exhausting, and I've never said that out loud.* (Not quite always: the birthday card, the car and the Sunday calls are Theo's, and he does them without being asked. But that isn't how it feels from the sink.) That set off something in both their bodies, and it made them worse at listening at exactly the moment they needed to listen.

Neither of them sat down and designed that evening. That's the trouble. Nobody designs it, so it designs itself, and left alone it tends to slide towards distance, because distance takes no choosing and closeness does.

The idea under this book is plain, and it took us years of watching these tools hold, fail and get rebuilt to believe it: **a relationship that runs entirely on feeling, with nothing agreed underneath it, isn't a purer or more romantic relationship. It's a relationship with nothing to fall back on.**

In our experience, romance lasts longer when something is holding it up. Everyone drifts; two busy people sharing a life always will. What matters is whether you notice it early, and fix it before it becomes distance nobody can name.

Taking love seriously looks like that: noticing the slow drain on the second day, not the eleventh.

GO DEEPER Manual Ch 1 (Why a Relationship Needs a Plan), Ch 2 (The Short Version) and Ch 9 (Micro-Repairs, where the 2% habit is explained)